RetailzPOS / Moolah Points — Daily Trending Topics Brief

October 23, 2026

Trending now — 3 topics with a genuine brand angle

#	Trend	Source	Brand-twist content idea
1	**South Carolina's first-ever statewide vape excise tax took effect October 1, 2026** — $0.05 per milliliter of consumable nicotine liquid. The first return, covering October, is due November 20, 2026. Liability depends on supply chain: a shop buying from an in-state licensed distributor owes nothing further, but a shop importing directly from an out-of-state manufacturer or mixing its own e-liquids counts as a distributor and must remit the tax itself.	WTOC — South Carolina's new vape tax takes effect; SC DOR — Nicotine Vapor Products Tax	**LinkedIn/Instagram, compliance post for SC vape/smoke retailers.** "South Carolina's new nicotine vapor tax took effect Oct 1 — and whether you owe anything on that first Nov 20 filing depends entirely on your supply chain. Buying from an in-state licensed distributor who already paid it? You're covered. Importing direct from an out-of-state manufacturer, or mixing your own e-liquids? You're the one who owes SCDOR. Worth confirming which bucket your shop falls into before that first deadline." A different state and a different mechanism (excise tax on volume, not a licensing/age-verification law) than the NC, VA, and Iowa stories already covered this month.

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2	**Kroger announced Oct 16, 2026 that it’s stocking 25 million pounds of Halloween candy this season**, including 9 million bags of fun-sized chocolate, and its own survey found 84% of shoppers plan to hand out candy this year. A specific, named-retailer inventory commitment — not a repeat of the national NRF spend totals already covered.	Finviz/PR Newswire — Kroger Is America’s Candy Destination	**Instagram/LinkedIn, last-weekend restocking nudge.** “Kroger just said it’s stocking 25 million pounds of Halloween candy this year — including 9 million bags of fun-sized chocolate — because their own data says 84% of shoppers are planning to hand it out. With 8 days left, that’s a clear signal: the last-minute candy run is about to hit every kind of store, not just the big grocery chains. Worth a final shelf check before the weekend.” Distinct from the costume-trend and total-spend angles already used Oct 9 and Oct 15 — this is a single named retailer’s fresh, dated inventory signal.

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3	**NRF released its official 2026 holiday forecast Oct 15** — November/December retail sales projected to hit $1.013 trillion, up 4.2% over 2025, the fastest growth since 2021. A follow-up consumer survey (Oct 20, Prosper Insights, n=8,094) found 56% of shoppers say the economy will affect their holiday spending, and gift cards remain the #1 wish-list item at 47%.	Chain Store Age / NRF — Holiday sales forecast; Bicycle Retailer — NRF forecasts 2026 holiday sales growth	**LinkedIn/Instagram, Moolah Points gift-card tie-in.** "NRF's official forecast: holiday retail sales hit $1.01 trillion this year, the fastest growth since 2021 — and in their newest survey, gift cards are still the #1 thing people want to receive, at 47%. That's real signal for anything gift-card or loyalty-related: if Moolah Points or a gift-card option isn't front and center at checkout right now, this is the season that gets tested." No pricing claim — ties an authoritative national forecast to gift-card visibility, distinct from the Yahoo DSP timing survey (Oct 20) and the Blackhawk redemption survey (Oct 17) already covered.

Skipped, no genuine angle today: World Series Game 1 ticket-resale surge (Milwaukee get-in prices near $3,100, driven by the Brewers' first World Series since 1982) — real and freshly dated, but too close in theme to yesterday's "big game traffic" angle to use as a distinct third topic; held rather than forced. "Suspect" TikTok audio trend — still live but produced no non-forced retail tie-in on this pass. Retail theft/shrink data (NRF's July 2026 report) — genuine but not dated to this week. GABF Oregon-brewery award results and a hemp-beverage industry lobbying item — both either already substantially covered by prior briefs or had an unconfirmed date.

Compliance check: none of the three ideas imply pricing, encourage overconsumption, or use underage-adjacent framing — #1 is a factual compliance/filing-deadline prompt with no product claim; #2 is a candy-restocking signal based on a named retailer's own

public data, with no age-restricted product involved; #3 ties a national economic forecast to gift-card/loyalty visibility with no discount or price mentioned.